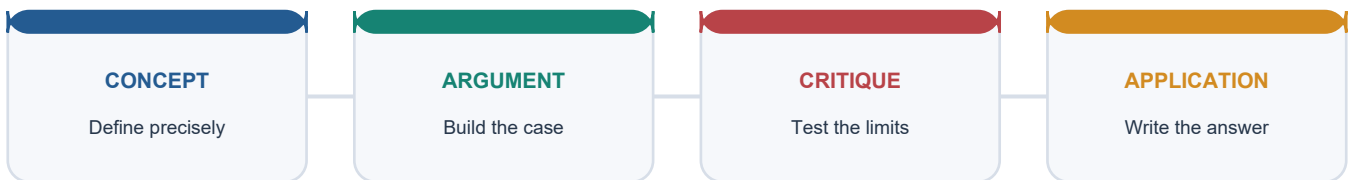


## SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

# Religious Pluralism and the Problem of Absolute Truth - Solved Practice Workbook

Standalone solved practice workbook · 32 hard MCQs · 12 verified PYQs · 6 original Mains models

### LEARNING PATH



*Deterministic fallback visual: move from precise concepts through argument and critique to exam application.*

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Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

# CONTENTS / WORKBOOK INDEX

Major learning parts and meaningful subtopics are listed in document order. Page numbers are generated from the final PDF layout; PDF bookmarks mirror the same hierarchy.

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# Religious Pluralism and the Problem of Absolute Truth - Solved Practice Workbook

Philosophy Optional · Philosophy Paper II - Philosophy of Religion · Topic 09 A standalone practice document. It is designed to be worked without the learning session open beside it, and it repeats no teaching prose.

## How to use this workbook

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap. The previous-year questions reproduce the official printed wording exactly; **the model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

## What is inside

| Part | Content                                               | Count   |
|------|-------------------------------------------------------|---------|
| 1    | Core diagnostic MCQs                                  | 24      |
| 2    | Remedial diagnostic MCQs                              | 8       |
| -    | Question-specific option explanations                 | 128     |
| -    | Unique examiner traps                                 | 32      |
| 3    | Verified previous-year questions, fully solved        | 12      |
| 4    | Original solved Mains models (2 x 10, 2 x 15, 2 x 20) | 6       |
| 5    | Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan          | 12 rows |

## Marking and timing conventions

- Word bands: 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words.
- Every model answer follows **claim -> named evidence -> analysis -> qualification**.
- Every model answer closes with a decided verdict, and the twenty-mark models additionally name the **defeater** that would change that verdict.
- **Standing penalties in this clause:** defining pluralism as "all religions say the same thing"; merging inclusivism with pluralism; presenting exclusivism only as bigotry; citing *ekam sat* without its native context or its bridging argument; quoting *extra ecclesiam nulla salus* as Cyprian's own words; omitting the 1965 qualification; treating "tolerance" as one thing; answering the conflict-history stem with a list of wars; and citing Huntington as a finding rather than as a thesis under sustained criticism.

## Terminology rule

English-first throughout. The English concept leads; the accurate Sanskrit, Pali, Greek, German or Latin term follows in parentheses.

## Self-scoring table

| Band    | Diagnostics correct (of 32) | What the Mains attempts show                                                                              |
|---------|-----------------------------|-----------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Weak    | 0-14                        | "All religions lead to the same God"; the triad named but not distinguished                               |
| Average | 15-20                       | Triad distinguished; Hick and Vivekananda present; exclusivism shown only as bigotry                      |
| Good    | 21-25                       | Truth, salvation, access and coexistence separated; one objection answered                                |
| Strong  | 26-29                       | Plantinga stated and met; RV 1.164.46 and Cyprian handled correctly; many-sidedness used as a logic       |
| Top     | 30-32                       | All the above, plus one discriminating distinction and an explicit acknowledgement of hard contradictions |

## Trap census

The thirty-two examiner traps below are distinct and non-repeating. Twelve of them correspond directly to the owner's printed trap list; the remaining twenty are answer-execution faults observed in this clause's directives.

## Independence note

Every model answer, original question, diagnostic item and option explanation in this workbook is **independent learner practice**. None reproduces an official mark scheme. Only the twelve previous-year questions are reproduced verbatim, from the audited repository ledger, and they are reproduced for practice routing.

## BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

### Practice protocol

Attempt every item before reading its key. The correct option position was fixed **independently for each question** by a randomised, length-balanced assignment: there is no rotation, no repeating cycle and no adjacent repetition to exploit, and each of the four positions carries exactly eight answers across the thirty-two diagnostics. Every option carries a question-specific explanation, and every question carries a unique examiner trap.

### CORE DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 24

#### MCQ 1. Which axis is the stem asking about?

A candidate is asked whether religious pluralism is defensible. Which statement expresses the **alethic** version of the pluralist thesis rather than one of the other three axes?

- A. Public institutions should neither privilege nor penalise any citizen on account of the religious community into which that citizen happens to have been born and raised.
- B. Discovering that informed and thoughtful people disagree about religion is a reason for holding one's own religious convictions with reduced confidence.
- C. Several traditions may state genuinely true things about ultimate reality, because no finite formulation of the absolute exhausts what it formulates.
- D. Adherents of more than one tradition are in fact liberated or saved by the discipline that their own tradition prescribes for them.

**Answer: C.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the **political coexistence** axis, and it can be held by an exclusivist who thinks every other religion false; it says nothing about the truth-value of doctrines.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is the **epistemic access** axis, specifically the conciliationist answer to peer disagreement; it concerns confidence rather than truth.

- **C:** Correct: the alethic axis asks which claims are true, and the pluralist answer is one absolute referent with non-exhaustive formulations, which is exactly what this option states.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is the **soteriological** axis, which concerns efficacy in liberating or saving and is separable from the truth of the doctrines involved.

**Examiner trap 1:** A script that never names which of the four axes it is discussing cannot be graded above the average band, however many thinkers it cites; name the axis in the opening sentence and hold to it throughout.

### MCQ 2. What distinguishes pluralism from relativism?

Which statement gives the correct differentia between religious pluralism and relativism?

- A. Pluralism restricts its attention to the great post-axial traditions, whereas relativism extends exactly the same generosity to every religious movement of any period without historical restriction.
- B. Pluralism typically affirms that there is a truth of the matter and denies that any finite formulation exhausts it, whereas relativism denies that there is any truth of the matter.
- C. Pluralism is a theory about how citizens should behave toward one another, whereas relativism is a theory about the semantics of the sentences that citizens use.
- D. Pluralism requires that religious claims be interpreted symbolically, whereas relativism permits them to be interpreted literally wherever the believer prefers that reading.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the scope of application is not the differentia; a relativist could restrict attention to post-axial traditions and would still be a relativist about their claims.
- **B:** Correct: relativism denies that there is anything to be right about, whereas pluralism affirms an ultimate referent and denies exhaustive possession of it by any finite perspective.
- **C:** Incorrect: this confuses the political-coexistence axis with the alethic axis, and both pluralism and relativism have positions on truth rather than only on conduct.
- **D:** Incorrect: symbolic interpretation is one of four reinterpreted moves available to pluralism, not its definition, and pluralism does not require it across the board.

**Examiner trap 2:** The relativism confusion is the commonest single failure in this clause; pre-empt it in the definition itself by writing that pluralism denies exhaustive possession of the absolute rather than denying that there is an absolute.

### MCQ 3. Citing the exclusivist formula correctly

Which statement handles the classical soteriological-exclusivist tag with the attribution discipline the clause requires?

- A. *Extra ecclesiam nulla salus* is the later standard phrasing of a doctrine traced to Cyprian, whose own wording in *Epistle 73* is *salus extra ecclesiam non est*.
- B. *Extra ecclesiam nulla salus* is Cyprian's own formulation in *Epistle 73* and was reaffirmed without alteration by the Second Vatican Council in 1965.
- C. *Extra ecclesiam nulla salus* originates with the Fourth Lateran Council of 1215 and has no earlier patristic ancestry of any kind in the Latin tradition.
- D. *Extra ecclesiam nulla salus* is a modern scholarly reconstruction with no conciliar standing, and it should therefore be omitted from an examination answer.

**Answer: A.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the compressed tag is the later standard phrasing; Cyprian's own wording is *salus extra ecclesiam non est*, and he also writes that one cannot have God as Father without the Church as mother.
- **B:** Incorrect on two counts: the tag is not Cyprian's wording, and Vatican II's *Lumen Gentium* 16 and *Nostra Aetate* moved the position decisively toward inclusivism rather than reaffirming it.
- **C:** Incorrect: Lateran IV in 1215 is part of the conciliar hardening of the formula, together with *Unam Sanctam* in 1302 and Florence in 1442, but the doctrine is traced to Cyprian in the third century.
- **D:** Incorrect: the formula has substantial conciliar standing, and omitting it would remove the classical statement of soteriological exclusivism from the answer altogether.

**Examiner trap 3:** Quoting the compressed Latin tag as Cyprian's own words is a factual error that an examiner can mark down directly; state the chain - Cyprian's wording, the later formula, the three councils, the 1965 qualification - and the citation becomes evidence of command.

### MCQ 4. What the 1965 documents did to the position

What is the correct significance of *Lumen Gentium* 16 and *Nostra Aetate* for an answer on religious exclusivism?

- A. They constitute the first formal statement of the exclusivist principle, which had until then circulated only as an informal patristic sentiment.
- B. They abolish the distinction between exclusivism and inclusivism by declaring that the question of salvation outside the Church is unanswerable.
- C. They move the Roman Catholic position decisively toward inclusivism, so that citing the exclusivist tag as the settled Christian view is a factual error.
- D. They confine the exclusivist principle to matters of ecclesiastical discipline while leaving its soteriological content entirely untouched and fully operative.

**Answer: C.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the exclusivist principle had already been given conciliar form at Lateran IV, in *Unam Sanctam* and at Florence, so 1965 is a qualification rather than a first statement.
- **B:** Incorrect: the documents do not declare the question unanswerable; they answer it in an inclusivist direction, which is a substantive position rather than an abstention.
- **C:** Correct: this is precisely the qualification the owner's discipline table requires, and omitting it turns a defensible citation into a factual error about the tradition's own teaching.
- **D:** Incorrect: the movement is soteriological rather than disciplinary, which is why the documents are the standard reference for the institutional shift toward inclusivism.

**Examiner trap 4:** Candidates frequently cite the Latin tag to establish that religions are inherently exclusivist and stop there; the same tradition supplies the counter-evidence, and using both halves of the chain demonstrates the historical control the strong band requires.

### MCQ 5. The differentia between inclusivism and pluralism

Which sentence states the difference between inclusivism and pluralism most exactly?

- A. On inclusivism others are included on terms set by the privileged tradition, whereas pluralism refuses to let any first-order tradition supply the adjudicating framework.
- B. On inclusivism other religions are held to be false, whereas on pluralism other religions are held to be true in every respect in which they make any claim at all.
- C. On inclusivism salvation is confined to one community, whereas on pluralism salvation is extended to sincere adherents of every community without exception.
- D. On inclusivism religious language is symbolic, whereas on pluralism religious language is literal and therefore capable of straightforward comparison across traditions.

**Answer: A.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the location of the standard is the differentia - inclusivism moves the boundary of who is saved without moving the standard, while pluralism relocates the standard to a second-order account.
- **B:** Incorrect: inclusivism grants other religions **partial truth**, which is precisely what distinguishes it from exclusivism, and pluralism does not hold that every claim is true.
- **C:** Incorrect: this misdescribes inclusivism, whose whole point is that salvation may reach beyond the community, and it overstates pluralism into a universalism about individuals.
- **D:** Incorrect: the semantics of religious language belongs to a different owner, and neither position is defined by a commitment to symbolic or literal reading.

**Examiner trap 5:** In the 2018 "distinguish" question the entire mark scheme is the three-way differentia; write one sentence per position that names **who sets the terms**, and the classification is complete before any thinker is discussed.

### MCQ 6. Stating the standard inclusivist model accurately

Which formulation of Rahner's "anonymous Christians" is accurate rather than a caricature?

- A. Adherents of other religions are secretly enrolled members of the Christian Church without having been informed of that enrolment by any ecclesiastical authority.
- B. Adherents of other religions will be saved only if they convert before death, so the description "anonymous" refers to the period preceding that conversion.
- C. Adherents of other religions are of interest only in so far as their traditions can be shown to contain doctrines materially identical with Christian ones.
- D. Adherents of other religions who respond to grace are, on the home tradition's own account, already related to the reality that the home tradition names.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the standard caricature, and it makes the position look absurd by converting a claim about the operation of grace into a claim about covert institutional membership.
- **B:** Incorrect: this reverts to exclusivism, since it makes salvation depend on conversion and therefore abandons the inclusivist extension that defines the position.
- **C:** Incorrect: doctrinal identity is not required by inclusivism, which grants **partial truth** and interprets it through the home tradition rather than demanding material coincidence.
- **D:** Correct: the claim is that the grace to which the other responds is, on the home tradition's account, the same grace it names differently, which is exactly the inclusivist structure.

**Examiner trap 6:** Refuting a caricature scores nothing; state the position in the form its defenders accept, and then press the asymmetry objection, namely that the home tradition is never itself redescribed in the other's categories.

### MCQ 7. What pluralism affirms and what it denies

Which pair correctly matches pluralism's central affirmation with its central denial?

- A. It affirms that religious language is wholly non-cognitive in character; it denies that religious claims can be assessed for truth or falsity by any philosophical procedure at all.
- B. It affirms that several traditions are authentic responses to ultimate reality or attain different real ends; it denies that any finite tradition exhaustively possesses the absolute.
- C. It affirms that all religions produce the same moral fruits; it denies that any doctrinal difference between traditions is of philosophical significance.
- D. It affirms that traditions should merge into a single global faith; it denies that historical particularity has value in the religious life.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: non-cognitivism about religious language is a separate thesis owned elsewhere, and pluralism as such takes religious claims to be truth-apt.
- **B:** Correct: this is the affirmation and denial as the owner states them, and the denial is what does the philosophical work in every subsequent argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: uniformity of moral fruits is neither claimed nor needed, and the claim that doctrinal differences are insignificant is the caricature pluralism exists to avoid.
- **D:** Incorrect: this describes syncretism, which every serious pluralism rejects, since Hick keeps the schemes distinct and Heim keeps the ends distinct.

**Examiner trap 7:** Defining pluralism positively as "all religions lead to the same God" places the script in the weak band immediately; define it by the denial of exhaustive possession, and the definition itself blocks four standard objections.

### MCQ 8. Reconstructing Hick's argument

Which sequence reproduces the argument for the pluralistic hypothesis in the order Hick gives it?

- A. Religious language is symbolic; symbols cannot conflict; therefore apparent doctrinal conflicts between traditions are merely verbal and dissolve on analysis.
- B. Every tradition produces saints; saints agree in their reports; therefore the traditions are describing one experience under different cultural vocabularies.
- C. No tradition can demonstrate its own claims; claims that cannot be demonstrated are all equally probable; therefore each tradition should be assigned exactly the same credence as every other tradition.
- D. Diversity is persistent and birth-linked; multiple traditions transform people; equal divine concern resists arbitrary exclusivism; therefore one Real may be experienced through different schemes.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is a religious-language argument, and it belongs to a different owner; Hick does not rest the hypothesis on the claim that symbols cannot conflict.
- **B:** Incorrect: agreement among mystical reports is a distinct and contested claim, and Hick's criterion is moral and spiritual transformation rather than concordance of reports.
- **C:** Incorrect: equal credence from undemonstrability is a sceptical argument that Hick does not make, and it would prove too much by levelling all religious claims indiscriminately.
- **D:** Correct: these are the four steps as the owner records them, with a descriptive premise, an evaluative premise, a theological premise and the hypothesis they jointly support.

**Examiner trap 8:** Describing Hick's position without reconstructing his argument caps the answer at the average band; number the premises, and then observe that premise three is theological and therefore unavailable against a non-theistic exclusivist.



### MCQ 9. What "transcategorical" means in Hick

What does Hick's description of the Real as transcategorical commit him to?

- A. The Real is a personal being whose attributes exceed human comprehension in degree while remaining of the same kind as human attributes.
- B. The Real is identical with the aggregate of all the religious experiences that the traditions have historically reported and preserved in their scriptures and commentarial literature.
- C. Personal and non-personal predicates apply to the Real's humanly experienced manifestations rather than literally to the Real as it is independently of human schemes.
- D. The Real is unknowable in the sense that no proposition about it can be asserted, including the proposition that the traditions are responses to it.

**Answer: C.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this makes the Real a personal being with superlative attributes, which is the classical theistic account that Hick's transcategoriality is designed to relativise.
- **B:** Incorrect: identifying the Real with the totality of religious experience would collapse the distinction between the Real and its manifestations that the hypothesis requires.
- **C:** Correct: this is exactly the doctrine - the personal and non-personal characterisations attach to manifestations, not to the Real as it is independently of the schemes.
- **D:** Incorrect: Hick does assert propositions about the Real, which is precisely why the noumenal objection about illicit predication arises rather than being pre-empted.

**Examiner trap 9:** Treating transcategoriality as simple unknowability makes the noumenal objection unanswerable and the hypothesis unstatable; the accurate formulation locates the predicates on the manifestations and leaves the objection where it actually bites.

### MCQ 10. Hick's use of Kant, and his departure from it

In what respect does Hick's use of the appearance/reality distinction depart from Kant's own position?

- A. Hick applies the distinction to moral rather than to theoretical judgements, so that the Real functions as a postulate of practical reason.
- B. Hick treats the noumenal Real as causally related to religious experience, which is a stronger commitment than the analogy by itself licenses.
- C. Hick denies that human conceptual schemes shape experience, holding instead that religious experience is a direct and unmediated apprehension.
- D. Hick restricts the distinction to non-theistic traditions, leaving theistic claims about God to be assessed in straightforwardly literal terms.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the Real is not introduced as a postulate of practical reason; it is introduced to explain the diversity of religious experience.
- **B:** Correct: this is the departure the owner records, and it is deliberate, since without a causal relation the Real would explain nothing about religious experience.
- **C:** Incorrect: the mediation of experience by conceptual schemes is the core of the analogy, and denying it would remove the explanation of diversity entirely.
- **D:** Incorrect: the distinction is applied across theistic and non-theistic traditions alike, which is what allows personal and non-personal characterisations to be treated symmetrically.

**Examiner trap 10:** Stating the Kantian analogy without stating the departure makes the noumenal objection look unmotivated; name the causal claim, and the objection follows from Hick's own commitments rather than from the critic's preference.

### MCQ 11. The noumenal objection, stated exactly

What exactly does the noumenal objection allege against Hick's hypothesis?

- A. That the traditions do not in fact report experiences of a single underlying reality, so the hypothesis is refuted by the very comparative evidence that it invokes in support of itself.
- B. That the Real cannot be worshipped, so the hypothesis leaves religious practice without an intelligible object of devotion in any tradition.
- C. That the hypothesis is unfalsifiable, since no observation could count against the claim that the traditions respond to one ultimate Reality.
- D. That if the Real is beyond all categories, then existence, causality and goodness are being illicitly predicated of it by the hypothesis itself.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is an empirical objection about comparative reports, whereas the noumenal objection is internal and concerns the consistency of the hypothesis with its own transcategoriality.
- **B:** Incorrect: the worship worry is a genuine but distinct concern, and Hick answers it by holding that the personal and non-personal manifestations are authentically encountered.
- **C:** Incorrect: unfalsifiability is a separate methodological complaint, and it does not turn on the transcategorial status of the Real at all.
- **D:** Correct: this is the objection as the owner states it, and it bites because the hypothesis needs the Real to exist, to cause experience and to be worth being oriented toward.

**Examiner trap 11:** The strongest form of this objection concedes that Hick can reply by treating the predications as formal rather than substantive, and then observes that the reply preserves consistency at the cost of informativeness - which is more accurate than declaring the hypothesis refuted.

### MCQ 12. The exact scope of the transformation criterion

What does Hick's soteriological criterion establish, and what does it leave undecided?

- A. It establishes that a tradition is an authentic response to the Real; it leaves undecided which of the traditions' contradictory doctrines are true.
- B. It establishes that the traditions' doctrines are jointly true; it leaves undecided which tradition produces the greater number of transformed adherents.
- C. It establishes that religious experience is veridical; it leaves undecided whether the Real is personal or non-personal in its own nature.
- D. It establishes that the traditions aim at the same end; it leaves undecided whether that end is correctly described as communion or as cessation.

**Answer: A.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the criterion assesses traditions for authenticity as responses and, in Hick's own statement, does not make contradictory doctrines jointly true.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is exactly what the criterion does **not** do, and the owner states the point explicitly to block the inference.
- **C:** Incorrect: the veridicality of religious experience is settled elsewhere and is presupposed rather than established by the soteriological test.
- **D:** Incorrect: whether the ends coincide is the very question Heim reopens, and the criterion is compatible with the ends differing rather than settling that they are one.

**Examiner trap 12:** Writing that transformation shows the traditions to be equally true concedes the relativism charge in a single sentence; the criterion is about traditions and the truth question is about propositions, and keeping them apart is what protects the answer.

### MCQ 13. The concern traditions themselves raise

Which objection to Hick's pluralism is the one that the traditions themselves characteristically make?

- A. That the transformation criterion is too permissive, since it counts as authentic any movement whose adherents report an improvement in their conduct.
- B. That the hypothesis is a form of natural theology and therefore requires a proof of God's existence that Hick nowhere supplies in his writings.
- C. That being redescribed as culturally limited appearances erases their self-understanding and weakens their witness or mission.
- D. That the hypothesis cannot accommodate traditions which arose before the axial period and therefore excludes most of recorded religious history.

**Answer: C.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: permissiveness is a real weakness of the criterion, but it is a philosopher's complaint about precision rather than the traditions' own objection.
- **B:** Incorrect: Hick's hypothesis is second-order and does not rest on a proof of God's existence, so this misidentifies the kind of claim being made.
- **C:** Correct: this is the identity and mission concern, and the owner's instruction is that dialogue requires hearing it rather than declaring it solved.
- **D:** Incorrect: the restriction to post-axial traditions is a scope decision within the hypothesis, not the objection that adherents themselves press against it.

**Examiner trap 13:** The three objections to Hick are one objection at three levels - metaphysical thinness, epistemic parity and existential redescription - and organising them that way is worth more than listing them as three separate complaints.

### MCQ 14. Plantinga's reply to the arbitrariness charge

How does Plantinga answer the charge that the exclusivist selects a tradition arbitrarily?

- A. By showing that the exclusivist's tradition can be independently verified through historical evidence unavailable to the traditions competing with it.
- B. By arguing that the charge of arbitrariness is harmless, because religious belief is simply not the kind of belief that requires grounds of any sort at all.
- C. By conceding the charge outright and relocating the exclusivist's confidence in a religious experience that is self-authenticating and beyond all public assessment.
- D. By observing that the pluralist also holds a contested belief that the exclusivist rejects, so at the meta-level both occupy the same position.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: no such independent verification is claimed, and the defence is epistemological rather than evidential in that historical sense.
- **B:** Incorrect: Plantinga does not treat religious belief as groundless; his framework is about warrant, and warrant is not the absence of grounds.
- **C:** Incorrect: the reply is not a concession relocated to private experience, and it does not appeal to self-authentication as a means of escaping the charge.
- **D:** Correct: this is the parity reply - the pluralist's own denial of unique truth is itself contested, so the exclusivist is not uniquely arbitrary in holding a disputed belief.

**Examiner trap 14:** Presenting Plantinga's replies without the two counters - that permissibility is not truth and that the contingency-of-birth problem remains untouched - makes the answer read as advocacy rather than assessment.

### MCQ 15. What the parity replies do and do not establish

If Plantinga's three replies succeed, what follows?

- A. That the pluralist position is incoherent, since it applies to first-order traditions a standard that its own second-order claim cannot satisfy.
- B. That exclusivism is rationally permissible, though nothing follows about its truth and the contingency-of-birth objection remains unanswered.
- C. That awareness of disagreement is epistemically inert, so a believer's confidence should be unaffected by discovering informed dissent.
- D. That religious disagreement is resolvable in principle, since the parties can be shown to share the standards by which warrant is assessed.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: that is D'Costa's separate charge against pluralism, not a consequence of Plantinga's replies, which establish parity rather than incoherence.
- **B:** Correct: the replies establish permissibility, and the owner records explicitly that they do not establish truth and do not address the contingency of birth.
- **C:** Incorrect: Plantinga's third reply concedes that awareness of disagreement may **reduce** warrant, and only denies that it extinguishes it.
- **D:** Incorrect: resolvability is precisely what the deep-disagreement literature denies, and nothing in the parity replies establishes a shared standard of assessment.

**Examiner trap 15:** The verdict ladder places "Plantinga's defence stated **and met**" in the strong band; stating it without meeting it, or meeting it without stating it, both fall short of what the band requires.

### MCQ 16. D'Costa's charge against the pluralist paradigm

What is the substance of D'Costa's objection to Hick?

- A. That pluralism makes its own second-order account uniquely true and reinterprets every tradition against that tradition's self-understanding.
- B. That pluralism cannot explain why religious traditions have historically produced conflict as well as reconciliation between their adherents.
- C. That pluralism depends on a comparative study of religions that is too incomplete to support the generalisations it needs to make.
- D. That pluralism confuses the psychological and social benefits of religious practice with genuine evidence for the existence of a transcendent reality behind that practice.

**Answer: A.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: this is the covert-exclusivism charge, which the owner records as the strongest single objection to Hick and which Hick's second-order reply does not fully escape.
- **B:** Incorrect: explaining the historical record is the business of the conflict-history module, and it is not what D'Costa's objection turns on.
- **C:** Incorrect: incompleteness of comparative data is a methodological worry of a different kind, and it is not the objection recorded here.
- **D:** Incorrect: this is a naturalistic objection to religious experience generally, owned elsewhere, and it does not target the pluralist paradigm specifically.

**Examiner trap 16:** Hick's reply that his is a philosophical hypothesis rather than a rival creed should be stated, and then answered by noting that a second-order theory which tells traditions what they are really doing exercises exactly the authority it denies them.

### MCQ 17. Identifying differential pluralism

Which claim is distinctive of S. Mark Heim's position in *Salvations* rather than of Hick's?

- A. The traditions are culturally conditioned responses to one transcategorical Reality that is not itself describable in the traditions' categories.
- B. Religious traditions should be assessed by the transformation they effect from self-centredness to Reality-centredness in their adherents.
- C. Dialogue between traditions should aim at the mutual transformation of both parties rather than at their subsumption under a neutral hypothesis.
- D. Communion, non-dual realisation and cessation are three destinations, not three descriptions of one destination.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is Hick's identist pluralism, and it is precisely the position Heim's differential pluralism is constructed as an alternative to.
- **B:** Incorrect: the soteriological transformation criterion is Hick's, and Heim's criterion is fidelity to the traditions' own self-understanding.
- **C:** Incorrect: mutual transformation is the Panikkar and Cobb proposal, which changes the aim of dialogue rather than the metaphysics of religious ends.
- **D:** Correct: differential pluralism holds that the ends themselves are plural, which is why the owner records it as preserving the traditions' self-understanding better than Hick does.

**Examiner trap 17:** Heim is more faithful to the traditions **and** surrenders the single ultimate that made pluralism attractive; writing only the first half turns an assessment into an endorsement.

### MCQ 18. Citing the Vedic verse with discipline

Which use of *ekam sad viprā bahudhā vadanti* satisfies the clause's attribution requirements?

- A. Cite it as Ṛgveda 1.164.46, note that its native subject is the naming of Vedic deities, and argue rather than assume the extension to inter-religious pluralism.
- B. Cite it as the Vedic teaching that all religions are equally valid paths to the same God, which the tradition has held continuously since the hymn was composed.
- C. Cite it as a late interpolation whose authority is disputed, and therefore use it only to illustrate what Indian pluralists have wrongly believed about their own texts.
- D. Cite it without a reference, since the line is sufficiently well known that a precise location would add nothing to an examination answer.

**Answer: A.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: these are the owner's four disciplines in operation - precise reference, native subject, argued extension - and they are what convert a slogan into evidence.
- **B:** Incorrect: the claim of continuous inter-religious application is false, since the extension is a nineteenth- and twentieth-century development requiring argument.
- **C:** Incorrect: the verse is not treated as a disputed interpolation, and dismissing it would discard the strongest short Indian text for the pluralist case.
- **D:** Incorrect: vague citation is the specific fault the discipline note targets, and it signals that the candidate has met the line only as a slogan.

**Examiner trap 18:** The verse earns marks because it separates one referent from many namings, and that separation is exactly what breaks the inference from absolute truth to exclusivism; used as a decorative quotation it earns nothing.

### MCQ 19. Vivekananda's demand, stated in his own terms

What does Vivekananda demand at the Parliament of the World's Religions, and why?

- A. Tolerance, on the ground that a plural society cannot survive without a settled legal framework for the peaceful management of religious difference.
- B. Doctrinal convergence, on the ground that the surviving differences between religions are verbal rather than substantive once analysed.
- C. Institutional unification, on the ground that separate religious organisations inevitably compete for adherents and therefore generate conflict.
- D. Acceptance rather than mere toleration, on the ground that toleration still condescends to the tradition it permits to exist.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: toleration is precisely what he regards as insufficient, so attributing that demand to him inverts his position.
- **B:** Incorrect: he preserves distinctive forms and denies homogenisation, so treating the differences as merely verbal misrepresents the model.
- **C:** Incorrect: institutional unification is not proposed; the model derives plural paths from plural temperaments and expects them to persist.
- **D:** Correct: this is his own emphasis at Chicago in 1893, and read against Forst's ladder it is a refusal of permission-level toleration.

**Examiner trap 19:** The 2025 stem names the thinker, so the mark scheme is fidelity to his own theses - the temperament argument, the four disciplines and the acceptance demand - rather than generic Vedāntic pluralism.

### MCQ 20. The status of the assimilation objection

How should the charge that Vivekananda's model is covertly neo-Vedāntic inclusivism be handled?

- A. Dismissed, because Vivekananda explicitly affirms that distinctive religious forms are preserved and that harmony does not require homogenisation.
- B. Accepted, because any position that supplies a metaphysical ground for religious plurality is by definition an inclusivism about the traditions it grounds.
- C. Stated with its reply and then left contested, since whether the metaphysical hierarchy remains inclusivist is not settled by the preservation of forms.
- D. Deferred to the Advanced block, because the objection concerns interpretive controversy rather than the doctrine an examination answer requires.

**Answer: C.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: preservation of distinctive forms answers part of the charge but does not settle whether Vedānta supplies the final adjudicating framework.
- **B:** Incorrect: supplying a metaphysical ground is not by itself inclusivism, since a second-order account may claim to privilege no first-order tradition.
- **C:** Correct: the owner's instruction is to keep the status contested, and the Advanced dossier records the same objection and reply without resolving them.
- **D:** Incorrect: the objection is directly examinable in the 2025 question and belongs in the core answer rather than in optional enrichment.

**Examiner trap 20:** Declaring the assimilation objection solved is as costly as ignoring it; the mature move is to state the reply, name what it does not settle, and let the contested status stand as the answer's evaluative conclusion.

### MCQ 21. Radhakrishnan's criterion and its characteristic risk

Which pairing correctly matches Radhakrishnan's criterion with the objection his position characteristically attracts?

- A. Criterion: integral experience - Risk: perennialist reduction, in which doctrines are demoted to variant readings of one underlying experience.
- B. Criterion: soteriological transformation - Risk: an empty Real, since the terminus of transformation cannot be described in any tradition's categories.
- C. Criterion: conditional predication - Risk: hard contradictions, since some claims conflict on the same question in the same respect.
- D. Criterion: fidelity to self-understanding - Risk: the surrender of a single ultimate reality behind the plurality of religious ends.

**Answer: A.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Correct: the inter-thinker grid records integral experience as his criterion and perennialist reduction as his main objection.
- **B:** Incorrect: soteriological transformation and the empty-Real objection belong to Hick, whose criterion is practical rather than experiential in Radhakrishnan's sense.
- **C:** Incorrect: conditional predication and the residue of hard contradictions belong to the Jain approach, not to Radhakrishnan.
- **D:** Incorrect: fidelity to self-understanding with the loss of a single ultimate is Heim's position, and it is in fact the opposite of a perennialist reduction.

**Examiner trap 21:** Radhakrishnan and Vivekananda are routinely merged; their criteria differ - integral experience against realisation - and so do their recorded risks, and separating them demonstrates control that a general "Indian pluralism" paragraph cannot.

### MCQ 22. Why conditional predication is not relativism

Why does the Jain apparatus of standpoint-indexed assertion avoid the charge of relativism?

- A. Because it applies only to claims about material substances and their properties, leaving claims about liberation, karma and the soul entirely outside its declared scope.
- B. Because the respects under which incompatible predicates are asserted are stated explicitly, so the assertions remain determinate and checkable.
- C. Because it is a monastic discipline for debate rather than a philosophical doctrine about the truth-conditions of assertions.
- D. Because it denies that finite knowers can make assertions at all, replacing assertion with a practice of principled silence.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the apparatus is general in scope, and restricting it to material substances would remove exactly the applications the clause needs.
- **B:** Correct: relativism denies a fact of the matter, whereas conditional predication states the respect and thereby regulates rather than abandons predication.
- **C:** Incorrect: it is a doctrine about how assertions must be qualified, not merely a debating convention, which is why it functions as a logic of standpoints.
- **D:** Incorrect: assertion is not abandoned; it is indexed, and the sevenfold scheme is precisely an enumeration of the available modes of assertion.

**Examiner trap 22:** Describing the elephant parable is worth markedly less than stating the apparatus as a logic that marks framework-relativity inside the proposition, which is what makes it a genuine contribution to the deep-disagreement problem.



### MCQ 23. The premise that carries the 2022 inference

The inference from "there is one Absolute Truth" to "religious exclusivism follows" is valid only if a further premise is supplied. Which premise is it?

- A. That religious traditions in fact make contradictory claims about the nature of ultimate reality rather than merely appearing to do so.
- B. That the state has an interest in the truth of religious doctrines and is therefore entitled to prefer one tradition over others.
- C. That a finite formulation can exhaust the absolute, so that one tradition's statement of it can be the whole truth about it.
- D. That religious experience is veridical, so that at least one tradition's reports about the absolute must be accepted as accurate.

**Answer: C.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: contradictory claims generate the problem but do not by themselves license exclusivism, since the contradiction could be resolved in favour of partial adequacy on all sides.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is a political premise about state action and belongs to a different axis; the inference under examination is alethic and epistemic.
- **C:** Correct: this is the suppressed premise, and Advaita's *nirguṇa* doctrine, Jain conditional predication and Hick's transcategorical Real each deny it independently.
- **D:** Incorrect: veridicality of experience is neither necessary nor sufficient for the inference, and denying it would not by itself block exclusivism.

**Examiner trap 23:** The 2022 stem is graded on whether the inference is tested rather than on whether the candidate agrees with it; concede the reading on which it succeeds, then deny the premise and the inference fails without any appeal to tolerance.

### MCQ 24. The control on hard contradiction

Which statement expresses the hard-contradiction control correctly?

- A. Contradictions between traditions are always apparent, since every apparent conflict can be resolved by distinguishing level, symbol, standpoint or soteriological end.
- B. Pluralism may reinterpret level, symbol, standpoint or end, but must acknowledge whatever contradiction remains rather than harmonising it.
- C. Contradictions between traditions show that at most one tradition is authentic, so pluralism is refuted wherever a genuine contradiction can be located.
- D. Contradictions between traditions are irrelevant to pluralism, which is a thesis about salvation rather than a thesis about the truth of doctrines.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this overstates the four reinterpetive moves into a universal solvent, which is exactly the rhetorical harmonisation the control forbids.
- **B:** Correct: the four moves are legitimate where a difference of respect can be specified, and the residue must be acknowledged; this is the owner's control verbatim in substance.
- **C:** Incorrect: a contradiction shows that at most one party is right **about that claim**, which is compatible with soteriological and political pluralism elsewhere.
- **D:** Incorrect: pluralism has an alethic dimension as well as a soteriological one, so contradictions between doctrines are directly relevant to it.



**Examiner trap 24:** The top band explicitly rewards acknowledging the contradictions pluralism cannot dissolve; a script that harmonises everything is not more generous than one that concedes the residue, it is simply less defensible.

## REMEDIAL DIAGNOSTIC MCQS - 8

### MCQ 25. Peer disagreement against deep disagreement

What distinguishes deep disagreement in Fogelin's technical sense from ordinary peer disagreement?

- A. Deep disagreement concerns religious questions specifically, whereas peer disagreement concerns questions in the empirical sciences.
- B. Deep disagreement occurs between parties of unequal competence, whereas peer disagreement requires the parties to be equally competent.
- C. Deep disagreement is about values while peer disagreement is about facts, so the two require different methods of resolution.
- D. Deep disagreement obtains when the parties do not share the framework propositions against which evidence would count at all.

**Answer: D.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: the distinction is structural rather than topical, and Fogelin's analysis is not restricted to religious subject matter.
- **B:** Incorrect: inequality of competence is not the criterion; parties to a deep disagreement may be perfectly matched in ability and evidence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the fact-value distinction does not track the difference, since framework divergence can arise about matters of fact as readily as about values.
- **D:** Correct: this is Fogelin's criterion, connected to Wittgenstein's hinge propositions in *On Certainty*, and it is why the same evidence is not evidence for the same thing.

**Examiner trap 25:** Peer disagreement assumes a shared framework and asks what to do about a peer; deep disagreement denies the shared framework, and conflating them makes both the conciliationist and the steadfast position unstatable.

### MCQ 26. What unresolvability does and does not show

If inter-religious disagreement is deep in the technical sense, what follows?

- A. That relativism about religious truth is thereby established, since a disagreement that argument cannot settle can have no fact of the matter standing behind it.
- B. That unresolvability is epistemic rather than alethic: one party may still be right, and what fails is our ability to demonstrate which.
- C. That dialogue is pointless, since parties who share no framework cannot communicate about the matters on which they differ.
- D. That pluralism is vindicated, since the persistence of disagreement is exactly what the pluralist hypothesis predicts.

**Answer: B.**

#### Option explanations:

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the inference the epistemic/alethic distinction blocks, and the owner records it as the objection to be answered rather than the conclusion to be drawn.
- **B:** Correct: this is the reply verbatim in substance, and it is the discriminating move the top band names.
- **C:** Incorrect: the analysis licenses only the retention of belief, not the refusal of dialogue, and it makes the procedural virtues obligatory rather than optional.
- **D:** Incorrect: consequence three states explicitly that pluralism cannot be established merely by pointing at the persistence of disagreement.

**Examiner trap 26:** The four consequences of deep disagreement cut in both directions - they protect the exclusivist from a charge of irrationality and deny the pluralist an easy argument - and using only the half that suits the script is visible to an examiner.

**MCQ 27. What makes an attitude toleration**

Which set of conditions is jointly necessary for an attitude to count as toleration?

- A. Objection to what is tolerated, reasons that outweigh but do not cancel the objection, and the power to interfere combined with deliberate restraint.
- B. Indifference to what is tolerated, absence of any power to interfere, and a general disposition to avoid conflict with one's neighbours.
- C. Approval of what is tolerated, a legal duty not to interfere, and a settled expectation that the other party will reciprocate in due course.
- D. Uncertainty about what is tolerated, willingness to revise one's own view, and a commitment to submit the disagreement to public argument.

**Answer: A.**

**Option explanations:**

- **A:** Correct: objection, acceptance and power are the three components, and removing the first yields indifference while removing the third yields mere endurance.
- **B:** Incorrect: indifference removes the objection component, which is precisely what makes toleration a moral achievement rather than an absence of concern.
- **C:** Incorrect: approval removes the objection component in the other direction, and a legal duty removes the deliberate restraint that the power component requires.
- **D:** Incorrect: this describes fallibilism and a commitment to public reason, which are valuable but are not what toleration means.

**Examiner trap 27:** In the 2020 tolerance question the definition does the work; define toleration by its three components first, and the importance the stem asks about follows from the definition instead of having to be asserted.

**MCQ 28. Grading a historical example on Forst's ladder**

A ruling majority permits a religious minority to practise its faith on sufferance, reserving the right to withdraw the permission. Where does this fall on Forst's ladder, and what follows?

- A. Esteem, since permitting practice acknowledges that the minority's beliefs contain something worthwhile.
- B. Respect, since the minority is being recognised as entitled to practise its faith without interference.
- C. Permission, which is what most historical toleration actually was and which is not compatible with equal citizenship.
- D. Coexistence, since the arrangement is a pragmatic settlement designed to avoid conflict between the two communities.

**Answer: C.**

**Option explanations:**

- **A:** Incorrect: esteem requires positively valuing the other's beliefs, and a revocable sufferance expresses no such valuation.
- **B:** Incorrect: respect requires reciprocal recognition as equal moral-political persons, which a unilateral and revocable permission by definition withholds.
- **C:** Correct: sufferance granted unilaterally by the powerful is Forst's first conception, and only respect and esteem are compatible with equal citizenship.
- **D:** Incorrect: coexistence is mutual and pragmatic, whereas the arrangement described is asymmetrical and dependent on the majority's continuing choice.

**Examiner trap 28:** Grade every historical example on the ladder before praising it; the habit converts a list of tolerant rulers into an argument, and it is what allows Vivekananda's demand for acceptance to be located precisely rather than merely admired.

**MCQ 29. The scope of Popper's paradox**

How should Popper's paradox of tolerance be stated in an examination answer?

- A. As a general principle that a society may suppress any doctrine which the majority of its citizens judges to be false or harmful.
- B. As the claim that unlimited tolerance destroys tolerance, with the right to refuse tolerance reserved for those who answer argument with violence.
- C. As an argument that tolerance is impossible in a plural society, since every act of toleration presupposes a power that will eventually be abused.
- D. As a rejection of Mill's harm principle, on the ground that harm is too vague a criterion to bear the weight of political limitation.

**Answer: B.**

**Option explanations:**

- **A:** Incorrect: this is the misuse the owner's trap list targets, since limits drawn by doctrinal content reproduce the intolerance they were meant to prevent.
- **B:** Correct: Popper's own formulation in the note to chapter 7 reserves the refusal for those who refuse rational argument and answer with violence.
- **C:** Incorrect: the paradox is a limit on tolerance rather than an argument for its impossibility, and Popper is defending the open society rather than despairing of it.
- **D:** Incorrect: the paradox is not a rejection of the harm principle; harm and reciprocity are precisely the criteria by which the limits should be drawn.

**Examiner trap 29:** Quoting Popper as a licence to suppress the intolerant is the single most misused citation in this clause; state the restriction in the same sentence as the paradox, and the citation becomes an argument rather than a slogan.

**MCQ 30. The hardest problem in religious freedom**

Which problem does the owner identify as the single most examinable tension in the religious-freedom question?

- A. Whether the state should fund religious institutions on the same terms as comparable secular institutions.
- B. Whether freedom of conscience extends to the refusal of medical treatment on religious grounds.
- C. Whether group rights granted to protect a community can entrench its dominant members over its own weaker members.
- D. Whether propagation should be permitted in public spaces or restricted to premises owned by the propagating community.

**Answer: C.**

**Option explanations:**

- **A:** Incorrect: funding questions are downstream of the neutrality models and are not identified as the central tension.
- **B:** Incorrect: this is an instance of the practice/belief asymmetry, which is a listed hard problem but not the one singled out.
- **C:** Correct: this is Shachar's paradox of multicultural vulnerability, which the owner records as the single most examinable tension in the clause.
- **D:** Incorrect: the propagation question is a listed hard problem whose principled line is coercion and fraud, but it is not the one identified as central.

**Examiner trap 30:** Answering a religious-freedom question with a list of constitutional articles leaves the philosophy untouched; the marks are in the asymmetry, the conversion line, the internal-minorities paradox, the two neutrality models and the state-as-arbiter-of-theology problem.

**MCQ 31. The analytic move in the conflict-history question**

Which distinction is the one that earns marks in answering whether the history of religions is the history of conflicts?

- A. Religion as cause, as marker of an antagonism generated otherwise, as mobiliser of grievance, and as legitimiser of a decision taken on other grounds.
- B. Religion as ancient and as modern, since pre-modern conflicts were fought over territory and dynastic succession while modern ones are fought over group identity.
- C. Religion as institutional and as personal, since institutions generate conflict whereas individual belief is politically inert.
- D. Religion as monotheistic and as non-monotheistic, since exclusive truth-claims arise only where a single deity is affirmed.

**Answer: A.**

**Option explanations:**

- **A:** Correct: this is the four-role distinction the owner identifies as the analytic move that earns marks, and most historical cases fall into the last three roles.
- **B:** Incorrect: a chronological split is the kind of periodisation Armstrong's argument complicates, and it does not isolate religion as a variable.
- **C:** Incorrect: the institutional/personal split does not track the causal question, and treating personal belief as inert begs the question at issue.
- **D:** Incorrect: exclusive truth-claims are not confined to monotheism, and the classification would prejudge the causal question by construction.

**Examiner trap 31:** A list of wars answers a different question from the one printed; grade the claim into its three versions, apply the four roles, then supply the counter-evidence, since a history that counts only the wars is a selected history.

**MCQ 32. The shape of the answer on religion as a unifier**

Which verdict on religion as a uniting force in a globalising world matches what the directive is buying?

- A. Religion unites, because every major tradition contains a version of the golden rule and a doctrine of universal moral standing.
- B. Religion divides, because Durkheimian integration is in-group integration and globalisation produces reactive and fundamentalist forms as readily as cosmopolitan ones.
- C. The question cannot be answered at all, because "religion" is not a stable independent variable that can be isolated from politics, land, economics and group identity.
- D. Religion unites conditionally: when its ethics are universalist in scope, its epistemology fallibilist enough for dialogue, and its identity not politically monopolised.

**Answer: D.**

**Option explanations:**

- **A:** Incorrect: this states one side of the evidence as though it were the verdict, and it cannot explain why the same traditions also produce communal violence.
- **B:** Incorrect: this states the other side as the verdict and is refuted by the same symmetry, since the traditions cited also produced the Parliament of Religions.
- **C:** Incorrect: the deconstruction of religion as a variable is a move within the conflict-history question, and using it here evades a directive that asks for a verdict.

- **D:** Correct: the directive decoder requires a conditional verdict with the conditions named, and these are the three conditions the owner's synthesis states.

**Examiner trap 32:** A conditional verdict is only an answer if the conditions are specified and independently checkable; "it depends" without the three conditions reads as evasion, while the three conditions read as analysis.

## PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

### Verified previous-year questions - 12 complete solutions

**Word bands used throughout.** 10 marks ≈ 150 words · 15 marks ≈ 250 words · 20 marks ≈ 350 words. Every question below is reproduced in its **exact printed wording** from the audited Philosophy of Religion previous-year ledger, 2018-2025, in which this clause owns **twelve question-parts out of 112** - two in each of 2018, 2019, 2020 and 2021, and one in each of 2022, 2023, 2024 and 2025. **The model answers are independent learner practice and are never official UPSC keys.**

**Timing skeleton.** 10 marks - 1 minute to decode, 1 to outline, 6 to write, 1 to check. 15 marks - 1 / 2 / 10 / 2. 20 marks - 2 / 3 / 13 / 2. **Standing penalties in this clause:** defining pluralism as "all religions say the same thing"; merging inclusivism with pluralism; presenting exclusivism only as bigotry; citing *ekam sat* without its context or its bridging argument; quoting *extra ecclesiam nulla salus* as Cyprian's own words; treating "tolerance" as one thing; answering the conflict-history stem with a list of wars; and citing Huntington as a finding.

### PYQ 1 - 2018, Q6(a), 20 marks

**Exact verified question:** Distinguish between Exclusivism, Inclusivism and Pluralism with regard to the conflicting truth-claims of different religions.

**Demand decoding:** "Distinguish A, B and C with regard to X" buys **three clean differentiae on one axis**. Fix the axis before distinguishing - here the printed axis is *conflicting truth-claims*, so truth is primary and salvation is secondary. A narrative of three thinkers will not score; a three-way differentia will.

**Model solution:** The three positions differ on a single question: **who sets the terms on which another tradition's claims are judged?**

**Exclusivism** holds that one revelation carries uniquely decisive truth and salvific authority, so where others contradict it they are mistaken. It appeals to determinate revelation and non-contradiction. Its classical soteriological expression is *extra ecclesiam nulla salus* - a later standard phrasing of Cyprian's *salus extra ecclesiam non est* (*Ep.* 73), hardened at Lateran IV (1215), *Unam Sanctam* (1302) and Florence (1442), then decisively qualified by *Lumen Gentium* 16 and *Nostra Aetate* (1965). Its strength is that it preserves determinate content; its weakness is privileged warrant, sharpened by the contingency of birth. It does not entail intolerance: Locke's argument that force cannot produce belief is available to it.

**Inclusivism** grants other traditions **partial truth** and possible salvation, but interprets that success through the home tradition - Rahner's "anonymous Christians". Others are included **on terms they have not set**; the standard does not move, only the boundary. Its cost is asymmetry: the home tradition is never redescribed in the other's categories.

**Pluralism** denies that any finite tradition exhaustively possesses the absolute. Hick's identist version treats the traditions as culturally conditioned responses to the transcategorical Real, assessed by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness; Heim's differential version holds that communion, non-dual realisation and cessation are three destinations rather than three descriptions. It is not relativism, indifferentism, syncretism or "all religions say the same thing".

Plantinga defends exclusivism by parity - the pluralist's own denial is contested too - while D'Costa charges pluralism with covert exclusivism. The triad is therefore a map, not a verdict.

### Why this earns marks:

- Fixes one axis at the outset, which is exactly what the directive buys.
- States each position by **who sets the terms**, giving three clean differentiae rather than three summaries.
- Carries the full attribution chain on the Latin tag, including the 1965 qualification.
- Distinguishes two varieties of pluralism, which most scripts treat as one.

- Closes with the parity exchange, converting classification into assessment.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** the compressible part is the conciliar chain - at 350 words, keep Cyprian's wording and the 1965 qualification and drop the three council dates. What must never be cut is the "who sets the terms" formula, because it is the differentia the directive is grading.

### PYQ 2 - 2018, Q6(b), 15 marks

**Exact verified question:** "Truth is one, yet people perceive differently." Critically evaluate by considering the present Indian context.

**Demand decoding:** A quotation **plus** a context clause. The clause carries marks, so an Indian application is compulsory. "Critically evaluate" requires the quotation to be tested, not endorsed.

**Model solution:** The statement distinguishes a single truth from plural perception: an absolute **referent** with perspectival **access**. Its strongest Indian anchor is *ekaṃ sad viprā bahudhā vadanti*, **R̥gveda 1.164.46**, from the *asya vāmasya* hymn attributed to Dīrghatamas. Yet its native subject is the naming of Vedic deities; extending it to world religions is a modern Vivekananda-Radhakrishnan-Gandhi argument, not the verse's unmediated meaning.

Advaita supports the structure through Brahman **without qualities** (*nirguṇa*), beyond exhaustive predication, and **with qualities** (*saguṇa*) forms. Jain many-sidedness (*anekāntavāda*) adds epistemic discipline: standpoint theory (*nayavāda*) and conditional predication (*syādvāda*) index assertions to a respect, rather than making every view true.

The statement therefore supports humility and equal respect in India, but not "all religions say the same thing." Gandhi's fallibilism and Sen's warning against singular affiliation explain its civic relevance. Hard contradictions nevertheless remain: a personal creator cannot both exist and not exist in the same respect. The maxim is defensible only as one referent with partial, corrigible access.

#### Why this earns marks:

- Reads the quotation as referent-versus-access rather than paraphrasing it.
- Applies the full citation discipline to RV 1.164.46, which the strong band requires.
- Uses *nirguṇa/saguṇa* and Jain many-sidedness as machinery, not as decoration.
- Answers the context clause with a determinate Indian application, including Sen.
- Concedes the hard-contradiction limit, which is what "critically" is buying.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 250 words, compress the Jain apparatus to one sentence naming *syāt* and standpoint-indexing. What must never be cut is the context clause, since omitting the Indian application forfeits marks the directive explicitly allocates.

### PYQ 3 - 2019, Q5(b), 10 marks

**Exact verified question:** Is religion a uniting force for humanity in the globalizing world as of today? Discuss.

**Demand decoding:** A "uniting force" stem buys a **conditional verdict with the conditions stated up front**.

Structure: for / against / conditions / verdict. Neither optimism nor cynicism scores.

**Model solution:** Religion is a conditional, not intrinsic, unifier. Durkheim shows how shared rites create collective effervescence and a moral community; the 1893 and 1993 Parliaments of the World's Religions and Hans Küng's *Declaration Toward a Global Ethic* illustrate transreligious cooperation.

Yet Durkheimian integration is also in-group demarcation. Huntington's clash thesis must be treated as a criticised thesis, while globalisation can generate both cosmopolitan networks and reactive identities. Religious symbols are also easily politically instrumentalised.

Religion unites humanity only when three conditions hold: its ethics are universalist, its epistemology is fallibilist enough for dialogue, and its identity is not politically monopolised. It is therefore a high-amplitude social force: the same traditions can sustain interfaith solidarity or communal division, depending on those conditions.

**Why this earns marks:**

- States the verdict form in the first line, so the structure is visible immediately.
- Uses Durkheim on both sides, which is what makes the citation analytical.
- Handles Huntington with the required qualification.
- Names three checkable conditions rather than gesturing at complexity.
- Ends with the amplitude formula, the clause's signature line for this stem.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 150 words, cut the list of universalist doctrines to one example and compress Roy to a clause. What must never be cut is the three-condition synthesis, because the conditions *are* the answer the directive is buying.

### PYQ 4 - 2019, Q7(a), 20 marks

**Exact verified question:** Expound and explain the central problem in the discussion between religious pluralists and religious exclusivists.

**Demand decoding:** "The **central** problem" is singular. Name it in one sentence, then unfold it. A survey of both positions without an isolated central issue answers a different question.

**Model solution:** The central problem is this: **is there any standpoint from which the competing claims of the traditions can be adjudicated without already occupying one of them?** Everything else in the dispute follows from that.

The exclusivist says no neutral standpoint is needed, because one revelation carries decisive authority; determinate truth and non-contradiction do the rest. The pluralist says a second-order account is available which privileges no first-order tradition: Hick relocates the centre to the transcategorical Real by four steps - persistent, birth-linked diversity; transformation produced across traditions; equal divine concern resisting arbitrary exclusivism; therefore one Real experienced through different conceptual schemes.

The problem bites in both directions. **Plantinga** answers the charges of arbitrariness, arrogance and irrationality by parity: the pluralist too holds a contested belief that the exclusivist rejects; believing what others deny is the ordinary condition of every philosopher; and awareness of disagreement may reduce warrant without extinguishing it. That establishes permissibility, not truth, and it leaves the contingency of birth untouched.

**D'Costa** answers from the other side: pluralism makes its own second-order account uniquely true and reinterprets traditions against their self-understanding - a covert exclusivism. Hick's reply, that his is a philosophical hypothesis rather than a rival creed, does not fully escape the charge, since a theory that tells traditions what they are *really* doing exercises the authority it denies them.

Underneath both lies **deep disagreement** in Fogelin's sense: the parties do not share the framework propositions against which evidence would count, so the failure of convergence is predicted rather than scandalous. It neither convicts exclusivism of irrationality nor establishes pluralism.



The central problem is therefore not which side is more generous but whether neutrality is available. It is not; what is available is corrigibility - fallibilism, humility, charity, and making one's framework explicit.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Names the central problem in a single sentence before unfolding it, exactly as the directive requires.
- Reconstructs Hick's argument in numbered steps rather than describing it.
- Gives Plantinga and D'Costa as a symmetrical pair, which is what makes the problem central rather than partisan.
- Adds the deep-disagreement layer, which the verdict ladder places in the strong band.
- Converts the stalemate into a determinate conclusion about corrigibility.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 350 words, compress Hick's four steps to two clauses. What must never be cut is the pairing of Plantinga with D'Costa, since a script with only one of them reads as advocacy rather than as an account of a *problem*.

**PYQ 5 - 2020, Q5(c), 10 marks**

**Exact verified question:** Is it acceptable that the History of Religions is the History of Conflicts? Discuss.

**Demand decoding:** A sweeping historical claim. **Grade it into versions**, refute the strong one, concede the narrow one. A list of wars answers a different question.

**Model solution:** The claim has three strengths: religions have been **involved** in conflicts; religion has sometimes been a **significant cause**; religion is the **defining engine** of conflict. The first is trivial, the third false, and only the second needs case-by-case proof.

Exclusivist certainty, sacralised authority and singular group identity can generate conflict; Kimball's markers are a useful typology, not a law. But Cavanaugh argues that "religious violence" depends on a modern religious/secular distinction; Armstrong warns against projecting that distinction backwards; Sen locates danger in the singular-affiliation fallacy.

Hence distinguish religion as **cause, marker, mobiliser or legitimiser**. Most cases combine political, economic and territorial factors. Counter-evidence-Aśoka's concord, Bhakti-Sufi universalism, abolitionism, civil rights and *satyāgraha*-also matters. The thesis is historically selective, though exclusivist certainty joined to monopolised identity remains genuinely dangerous.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Grades the claim in the first sentence, which is the structural consequence the directive demands.
- States the case *for* fairly before refuting it.
- Deploys the four-role distinction, which the owner identifies as the mark-earning move.
- Supplies counter-evidence, making the refutation historical as well as conceptual.
- Concedes a narrow truth, which is what "discuss" is buying.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 150 words, reduce the counter-evidence list to three items. What must never be cut is the four-role distinction, because without it the answer becomes the list of wars the trap list forbids.



### PYQ 6 - 2020, Q5(e), 10 marks

**Exact verified question:** What is the importance of religious tolerance in a multicultural pluralistic society? Justify your answer.

**Demand decoding:** "Importance ... justify" means the importance must be **argued**, not asserted. Define tolerance properly first: the definition does the work.

**Model solution:** Tolerance is not indifference. It requires **objection**, overriding **acceptance reasons**, and the **power** to interfere combined with restraint. Its paradox-allowing what one believes wrong-is resolved by separating first-order disagreement from second-order reasons against coercion.

Its importance follows from those reasons. Locke argues that force cannot produce belief; Mill adds harm and the epistemic cost of suppression. Aśoka's Rock Edict XII forbids disparaging other sects and commends concord (*samavāya*); Gandhi adds fallibilist equal respect, while Vivekananda demands acceptance rather than condescending toleration.

Forst's ladder-permission, coexistence, respect, esteem-shows the limit: tolerance granted by the strong may remain permission. It is therefore indispensable for peaceful disagreement but insufficient for equality; a plural society needs respect-based toleration bounded by harm and reciprocity.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Defines by three components, so the importance is derived rather than asserted.
- States the paradox and resolves it by levels, which is the philosophical core.
- Gives both argument-stocks, with Aśoka correctly identified as the earliest verifiable state-level argument.
- Applies Forst's ladder as a grading instrument rather than a list.
- Closes with the indispensable-but-insufficient verdict, naming both reasons.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 150 words, keep the three components, Locke, Aśoka and the ladder; compress Mill, Rawls and Popper into one clause. What must never be cut is the power component, since the closing verdict depends on it.

### PYQ 7 - 2021, Q5(b), 10 marks

**Exact verified question:** Discuss the possibility of Absolute Truth in the context of religious pluralism.

**Demand decoding:** A **possibility** claim. The examiner is buying the **compatibility mechanism**: absolute referent with perspectival access. Show the mechanism, do not merely assert the compatibility.

**Model solution:** Absolute Truth is compatible with religious pluralism once four questions are separated: **referent, formulation, epistemic access and salvation**. Pluralism need not deny an absolute referent; it denies that any finite formulation exhausts it.

The mechanism is ontological unity without epistemic monopoly. Advaita's Brahman without qualities (*nirguṇa*) exceeds exhaustive predication while with-qualities (*saguṇa*) forms guide devotion. Jain conditional predication (*syādvāda*) indexes assertions to standpoints, and Hick calls the Real transcategorical. These are distinct ways of rejecting the suppressed premise that one finite statement can possess the absolute completely.

The view assumes that truth permits partial adequacy or non-literal mediation. It also cannot dissolve direct contradiction in the same respect. Absolute Truth is therefore possible as one inexhaustible referent approached fallibly, not as one finite formulation held with unquestionable certainty.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Separates referent, formulation, access and salvation, which is the owner's instruction for every absolute-truth stem.
- Exhibits the compatibility **mechanism**, which is what a possibility directive buys.
- Cites three independent denials of the suppressed premise, one Western and two Indian.
- Names the presupposition the position itself makes.
- Concedes the hard-contradiction residue in the same answer.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 150 words, keep the four-way separation and one denial of the premise. What must never be cut is the closing distinction between a single referent inexhaustibly formulated and a finite formulation held absolutely, since that sentence is the possibility claim.

**PYQ 8 - 2021, Q5(c), 10 marks**

**Exact verified question:** Is religious freedom possible in a multireligious society? Explain.

**Demand decoding:** Feasibility, **with the hard cases faced**. Naming rights without facing the practice/belief asymmetry and the internal-minorities problem will not reach the upper bands.

**Model solution:** Religious freedom is possible-and especially necessary-in a multireligious society, but it cannot be unlimited or perfectly neutral. It includes conscience, profession, practice, propagation, change or exit, freedom from compelled observance, and community association.

Locke's incoercibility argument is decisive: coercion produces profession, not belief. Autonomy and deep disagreement add reasons against state certainty. Yet belief and practice differ: practice may be limited by public order, morality, health, harm and reciprocity. Propagation protects persuasion, not coercion or fraud.

The hardest issue is Shachar's **multicultural vulnerability**: group protection can empower dominant insiders over women or dissenters. Bhargava's **principled distance** therefore improves on both strict separation and religious establishment by permitting differential engagement for freedom and equality. Religious freedom is feasible only with individual exit, internal-minority safeguards and justified limits on harmful practice.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Separates the bundle, so that "possible" can be answered differently for different members.
- Gives four independent justifications rather than one.
- Faces all the hard cases, including the one the owner calls the most examinable tension.
- Contrasts two neutrality models and explains what principled distance permits.
- Ends with a qualified verdict that names the residual cost.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 150 words, compress the four justifications to Locke plus one. What must never be cut is the internal-minorities paradox, since it is the discriminator between an average and a good script on this stem.

**PYQ 9 - 2022, Q7(a), 20 marks**

**Exact verified question:** "An unquestionable acceptance of only one Absolute Truth will inevitably result in religious exclusivism." Discuss.

**Demand decoding:** A quotation whose **inference** is to be tested, not its mood. The word doing the work is "inevitably". Show that ontological absolutism does not entail epistemic exclusivism.

**Model solution:** The claim asserts an entailment. Reconstructed, it runs: there is exactly one Absolute Truth; a finite formulation can exhaust it; my tradition's formulation is that one; therefore every other tradition is simply mistaken. The argument is valid. It is unsound if either suppressed premise fails.

On one reading the inference does succeed, and that must be conceded first. If "absolute truth" means *my religion's propositions are the sole truth*, exclusivism follows immediately - indeed trivially, because exclusivism has been built into the premise.

But one may hold that there **is** an Absolute Truth - the Real, or Brahman - while recognising all religions as **partial and perspectival** approaches to it: an absolute **referent** with pluralist **access**. That breaks the link. Three traditions deny the suppressed premise independently. Advaita's Brahman **without qualities** (*nirguṇa*) is beyond exhaustive predication, while **with-qualities** (*saguṇa*) forms structure real devotional paths. Jain **many-sidedness** holds reality many-sided and every viewpoint partially true, with conditional predication (*syādvāda*) indexing assertions to a standpoint. Hick's Real is transcategorical, so personal and non-personal predicates attach to manifestations rather than to the Real itself.

Ontological absolutism, epistemic fallibilism and political tolerance are three separate theses. Establishing the first settles neither of the others - which is why an exclusivist may consistently defend religious freedom on Locke's ground that force cannot produce belief, and why tolerance cannot be inferred from metaphysics without an additional premise.

Two concessions keep the answer honest. The reply presupposes that truth admits degrees of adequacy or non-literal mediation. And hard contradictions remain: a personal creator either exists or does not, and pluralism must acknowledge that residue rather than harmonise it.

The entailment therefore fails. Ontological absolutism entails epistemic exclusivism only if one adds the premise that a finite formulation can exhaust the absolute - and that premise is exactly what Advaita's *nirguṇa* and Jain many-sidedness deny.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Reconstructs the argument formally and locates the suppressed premises, which is what "discuss" a claim means.
- Concedes the reading on which the inference succeeds before denying the other.
- Supplies three independent denials of the premise, two of them Indian.
- Separates the three theses explicitly, blocking the tolerance-from-metaphysics slide.
- Concedes both limits, which is what the top band rewards.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 350 words, compress the three denials to Advaita plus Jainism. What must never be cut is the formal reconstruction, since the whole answer depends on exhibiting a premise the quotation leaves unstated.

**PYQ 10 - 2023, Q8(b), 15 marks**

**Exact verified question:** Does religious pluralism invite inter-religious conflicts and destroy the truth of religion? Discuss.

**Demand decoding: Two allegations, answered separately.** Conflict-generation and truth-destruction are different charges, and a single undifferentiated reply loses half the marks.

**Model solution:** The stem makes two distinct charges.

**Conflict:** pluralism may appear to weaken commitment and provoke reaction, but plurality alone does not cause violence. The better analysis distinguishes religion as **cause, marker, mobiliser and legitimiser**. Sen's singular-affiliation critique shows how monopolised identity, political power and exclusivist certainty mediate conflict. Political coexistence requires reciprocity and harm-limitation, not agreement about truth.

**Truth:** pluralism does not have to equalise propositions. Hick relocates absoluteness in the transcategorical Real and interprets traditions as culturally conditioned responses; this distinguishes equal dignity or salvific efficacy from identical propositional truth. Thus it denies exhaustive possession, not truth itself.

Two limits remain. Direct contradictions-such as creator and no creator in the same respect-cannot both be true; they must be routed through level, symbol, standpoint or different end, with residue acknowledged. Further, D'Costa argues that pluralism redescribes traditions through its own superior meta-framework and is therefore covertly exclusivist.

Pluralism need neither invite conflict nor destroy truth, but only if it retains non-contradiction, respects self-description and refuses to infer metaphysics from civic tolerance.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Splits the two allegations explicitly, which the directive requires.
- Answers the conflict charge with the four-role analysis rather than with reassurance.
- Answers the truth charge with the dignity-versus-truth distinction, which is the recorded reply.
- Concedes the hard-contradiction residue and the identity objection.
- Ends with the relocation formula and its qualification.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 250 words, compress the four-role analysis to a single clause. What must never be cut is the explicit separation of the two charges, since a merged answer forfeits the structure the directive is grading.

### PYQ 11 - 2024, Q5(b), 10 marks

**Exact verified question:** Write a note on the notion of absolute truth in the context of religion.

**Demand decoding:** A **notion** question. It asks for the concept to be analysed, not for a verdict on a controversy. The four-way separation *is* the analysis.

**Model solution:** "Absolute truth" in religion is truth claimed to be unconditioned by person, period or perspective. Four distinctions clarify the notion.

**Referent:** the Real, Brahman or God may be ontologically absolute. **Formulation:** every statement of that referent uses a language and conceptual scheme, so the statement need not be exhaustive. Advaita marks this through Brahman without qualities (*nirguṇa*) and with qualities (*saguṇa*). **Access:** finite knowers may grasp aspects rather than totality; Jain conditional predication (*syādvāda*) indexes claims to a standpoint. **Salvation:** whether possession of truth exclusively liberates is a further question.

Thus ontological absolutism does not entail epistemic monopoly or political privilege. The notion remains coherent if absoluteness belongs primarily to the referent, finite formulations remain corrigible, and contradictions surviving reinterpretation are acknowledged rather than harmonised.

**Why this earns marks:**

- Treats the stem as conceptual analysis, which is what "write a note on the notion" asks for.
- Gives four distinctions, each with a named tradition attached.
- Draws two consequences instead of leaving the analysis inert.
- Uses *nirguṇa/saguṇa* as a tradition's own internal marking of the point.
- Closes with the discipline that keeps absoluteness on the referent.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 150 words, drop one of the two consequences. What must never be cut is the four-way separation, since it is the analysis the notion-question is asking for.

### PYQ 12 - 2025, Q7(a), 20 marks

**Exact verified question:** How does the Vedāntic view of Religious Pluralism address the conflicting truth claims of different faiths? Answer with reference to Swami Vivekananda's view of Universal Religion.

**Demand decoding:** "**How does X address...?**" Answer with reference to [thinker]" buys a **mechanism** plus **fidelity to the named thinker**. Generic Vedānta does not score; Vivekananda's own theses do.

**Model solution:** The Vedāntic response addresses conflicting truth-claims by a single move: it separates the **one referent** from the **many formulations**, and then explains the plurality of formulations by the plurality of human temperaments.

The textual anchor is *ekam sad viprā bahudhā vadanti*, **Ṛgveda 1.164.46**, from the *asya vāmasya* riddle-hymn ascribed to Dīrghatamas. Discipline is required: its native subject is the naming of Vedic deities, and the inter-religious extension is a nineteenth- and twentieth-century development that must be argued. What the verse supplies is the structure - one existent, many namings.

Vivekananda's **Universal Religion** supplies the mechanism. Human capacities vary; spiritual disciplines must therefore vary; the non-dual ground supplies a common metaphysical reference; and the test is **realisation**, not doctrinal uniformity. The four disciplines - knowledge (*jñāna*), devotion (*bhakti*), action (*karma*) and meditative discipline (*rāja*) - address distinct dispositions. Plurality of path is therefore *expected*, not merely tolerated. At the Parliament of the World's Religions in Chicago in 1893 he demands **acceptance, not mere toleration**, on the ground that toleration still condescends.

Conflicting claims are handled at two levels: Brahman **without qualities** (*nirguṇa*) is beyond exhaustive predication, while **with-qualities** (*saguṇa*) forms structure real devotional paths. Jain many-sidedness adds an epistemic discipline - every judgement is standpoint-indexed - and so dogmatic exclusivism is dissolved without abandoning truth.

Two evaluations are required. Against Hick, the Vedāntic model grounds pluralism metaphysically rather than in a transcategorical Real that is arguably too thin to describe. Against Heim, it owes an argument: it does not follow without proof that traditions seeking personal communion, creator relation or cessation all reach the same end. And the

standing objection is assimilation - if Vedānta supplies the final meta-framework, other faiths are included on terms they have not set, which is inclusivism. Vivekananda answers that distinctive forms are preserved and harmony does not require homogenisation; whether the metaphysical hierarchy remains inclusivist is **contested**.

The Vedāntic view therefore addresses conflicting truth-claims by relocating absoluteness in the referent and deriving plurality from temperament - a strong and specifically Indian pluralism whose unresolved question is whether its own framework is neutral.

#### Why this earns marks:

- Names the mechanism in the first sentence, which is what "how does" buys.
- Applies the full citation discipline to RV 1.164.46 rather than quoting it as a slogan.
- Uses Vivekananda's own theses - temperaments, the four disciplines, acceptance over toleration.
- Places the model against Hick and Heim, which converts exposition into assessment.
- Leaves the assimilation objection contested, as the owner requires.

**Upgrade route for this answer:** at 350 words, compress the Jain addition to one clause. What must never be cut is the assimilation objection with its reply and its contested status, since that is the evaluative move the 20-mark band is grading.

### Original solved Mains practice - 6 models

These six questions are **learner-written practice**, not previous-year questions. They are constructed to drill the demands the printed corpus has not yet combined.

#### Original 1 · 10 marks

**Question:** Distinguish between alethic and soteriological religious pluralism, and state one consequence of the distinction. (*Answer in about 150 words.*)

**Model answer:** Alethic pluralism concerns the **truth** of religious claims: it holds that several traditions state genuine truths about ultimate reality, because no finite formulation exhausts what it formulates. Soteriological pluralism concerns **efficacy**: it holds that several traditions really transform, liberate or save their adherents.

The two are separable in both directions. One may hold that another tradition's doctrines are largely mistaken while conceding that its practice transforms; one may hold that its doctrines are substantially true while denying that its path is efficacious for salvation.

The consequence is decisive for the standard argument. Hick's soteriological criterion - transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness - assesses traditions for authenticity and, by his own statement, does **not** render contradictory doctrines jointly true. A script that treats the criterion as settling the truth question has conceded the relativism charge without argument, since it has answered an alethic objection with soteriological evidence.

**Why this earns marks:** It defines both axes, demonstrates their logical independence through two counter-directions, and uses Hick's named criterion to show the precise examination consequence without confusing efficacy with truth.

#### Original 2 · 10 marks

**Question:** "Toleration granted by the strong to the weak is permission, not equality." Examine. (*Answer in about 150 words.*)

**Model answer:** The statement is correct, and its force comes from the **power component** in the concept of toleration itself.

Toleration requires three things: an objection to what is tolerated, reasons that outweigh without cancelling that objection, and the power to interfere combined with deliberate restraint. The third condition means that toleration is always exercised by someone who *could* have done otherwise.

Forst's ladder makes the consequence explicit. **Permission** is the powerful allowing a minority to exist on sufferance; **coexistence** is a pragmatic modus vivendi; **respect** is reciprocal recognition as equal moral-political persons; **esteem** positively values the other's beliefs. Only respect and esteem are compatible with equal citizenship, and most historical toleration was permission.

Vivekananda reaches the same conclusion from the other direction, demanding acceptance rather than toleration because toleration still condescends. Toleration is thus indispensable - the objection component makes it a moral achievement - and insufficient.

**Why this earns marks:** It derives the conclusion from the power component, applies Forst's four-level distinction, adds Vivekananda as an independent Indian comparator, and ends with a qualified rather than celebratory verdict.

### Original 3 · 15 marks

**Question:** Assess the claim that Hick's pluralistic hypothesis is a covert exclusivism. (*Answer in about 250 words.*)

**Model answer:** D'Costa's charge is the strongest single objection to Hick. Hick treats major traditions as culturally conditioned responses to the transcategorical Real, judged by transformation from self-centredness to Reality-centredness. He calls this a **second-order** philosophical hypothesis, not another creed.

D'Costa replies that the second-order theory is still presented as uniquely true and redescribes every tradition against its own self-understanding. Hick's distinction of levels therefore relocates privileged authority rather than abolishing it: a theory that tells traditions what they are "really" doing performs the adjudication it denies to them. The identity and mission objection confirms this cost.

Two qualifications matter. First, the criticism is diagnostic, not constructive: lack of neutrality does not establish exclusivism, and Plantinga's parity defence proves at most that exclusivist belief may remain rational. Second, not every pluralism bears the charge equally. Heim's differential pluralism treats communion, non-dual realisation and cessation as different real ends, preserving self-description better than Hick, though surrendering one ultimate destination.

Hickian pluralism is therefore not neutral, but neither is its rival. The decisive standard is whether the framework is explicit, corrigible and responsive to the traditions it interprets.

**Why this earns marks:** It reconstructs D'Costa's objection fairly, tests Hick's second-order reply, distinguishes diagnosis from proof of exclusivism, and compares Heim to show that the objection does not strike every pluralism equally.

### Original 4 · 15 marks

**Question:** How far does Jain many-sidedness (*anekāntavāda*) resolve the problem of conflicting religious truth-claims? (*Answer in about 250 words.*)

**Model answer:** It resolves a substantial part of the problem and leaves a residue that must be conceded.

The apparatus is three-tiered. **Many-sidedness** (*anekāntavāda*) holds reality to be many-sided; **standpoint theory** (*nayavāda*) makes explicit the standpoint from which a judgement is made; **conditional predication** (*syādvāda*) prefixes assertions with *syāt*, "in a certain respect", and the **sevenfold scheme** (*saptabhāṅgī*) enumerates the modes. Framework-relativity is thereby marked **inside** the proposition rather than left implicit.

This is not relativism. Relativism denies that there is a fact of the matter; conditional predication states the respect under which a predicate holds, so the assertions remain determinate and checkable. Predication is regulated, not abandoned.

Its power appears at two points. In the absolute-truth debate it denies the premise that a finite formulation can exhaust the absolute, so belief in one absolute Truth no longer entails exclusivism. In the epistemology of disagreement it addresses Fogelin's problem directly: deep disagreement arises because parties do not share the framework against which evidence would count, and the Jain device makes that framework explicit - a genuine Indian contribution to a live Western problem, and worth far more than the parable of the elephant.

Its limit is exact. The apparatus works wherever a difference of aspect, level or soteriological orientation can be specified. Where two claims contradict on the same question in the same respect - a personal creator exists, or does not - no index of standpoint helps. There, pluralism must distinguish literal conflict, symbolic language and different soteriological aims, and acknowledge whatever contradiction survives.

**Why this earns marks:** It explains the full Jain apparatus in English-first form, shows two distinct applications, rejects the relativist caricature, and concedes the exact same-respect contradiction that limits the doctrine.



### Original 5 · 20 marks

**Question:** "Political coexistence between religions neither requires nor follows from agreement about religious truth." Critically discuss with reference to both Western and Indian resources. (Answer in about 350 words.)

**Model answer:** The statement contains two claims, and both are defensible.

**Coexistence does not require truth-agreement.** Locke's *Letter Concerning Toleration* (1689) argues that the magistrate has no commission over souls and that force produces profession, not belief. The argument is available even to an exclusivist. Mill adds harm and the epistemic value of dissent; Rawls explains stability through an overlapping consensus among incompatible doctrines. Aśoka's Rock Edict XII similarly commends concord (*samavāya*) and condemns disparagement without requiring shared theology.

**Coexistence does not follow from truth-agreement.** A metaphysical claim needs an additional political premise about coercion, harm or reciprocity. Thus an exclusivist may respect freedom, while a self-described pluralist may still coerce.

Three qualifications are necessary. Forst's ladder distinguishes permission, coexistence, respect and esteem: majority permission is not equal citizenship. Popper's paradox permits limits only where intolerant actors reject argument and answer with violence; practice may likewise be limited by harm, public order, morality and health. Finally, Shachar's multicultural vulnerability shows that accommodation between groups may empower dominant insiders over women or dissenters.

Indian resources deepen the conclusion. Vivekananda's demand for acceptance rather than toleration exposes condescension, while Gandhi's equal respect rests on fallibilism about one's grasp of truth. Jain many-sidedness supplies an epistemic reason to state one's standpoint explicitly.

Political coexistence therefore depends on respect, reciprocity, exit and harm-limits-not on doctrinal agreement. The claim would fail only if a religious truth itself entailed coercion and no independent moral or political reason could defeat that entailment.

**Why this earns marks:** It proves both halves of the quotation separately, links Western and Indian evidence to the claims they support, faces permission, intolerance and internal-minority objections, and states the defeater that would reverse the conclusion.

### Original 6 · 20 marks

**Question:** Examine whether the epistemology of deep disagreement strengthens or weakens the case for religious pluralism. (Answer in about 350 words.)

**Model answer:** It does both, and the balance is what makes it examinable.

**The apparatus.** Within a shared framework, the dispute is between **conciliationism** or equal weight (Feldman, Christensen), on which discovering peer disagreement should reduce confidence, and **steadfastness** (Kelly, van Inwagen), on which one may retain a belief because one's own reasoning is part of one's evidence; the **independence principle** - assess the disagreement without relying on the reasoning under dispute - is what conciliationism needs and steadfastness denies. **Deep disagreement**, in Fogelin's technical sense (1985), goes further: the parties do not share the **framework propositions** - Wittgenstein's hinge commitments in *On Certainty* - against which evidence would count, so the same evidence is not evidence for the same thing. Lynch extends the analysis to disagreement about epistemic principles themselves, where any defence is circular.

**Why religion is a paradigm case.** The parties differ over the sources of evidence, the criteria of adequacy - salvation, liberation, cessation - and the framework in which any datum would count.

**Where it weakens pluralism.** Two consequences cut against it. Exclusivism cannot be convicted of irrationality merely for persisting, which removes the easiest charge against it and gives Plantinga's third reply its technical backing. And pluralism cannot be established merely by pointing at persistence - the persistence that seemed to support Hick's first premise is now explained without any pluralist assumption.

**Where it strengthens pluralism.** Two further consequences cut in its favour. The failure of convergence is *predicted* rather than scandalous, so it is weak evidence for relativism. And what *can* be rationally required are the **procedural virtues** - fallibilism, humility, epistemic charity, and willingness to make one's framework explicit - which is precisely the ethic pluralism recommends. Jain conditional predication is the most developed attempt to make framework-relativity explicit inside the proposition.



**The verdict.** Deep disagreement weakens the case for pluralism as a *demonstrated metaphysics* and strengthens it as an *ethic of engagement*. Unresolvability is epistemic, not alethic: one party may still be right, and what fails is our capacity to show which. That is a smaller claim than Hick's, and it is more defensible.

**Why this earns marks:** It distinguishes peer from deep disagreement, names the competing epistemologists and their hinge, derives two consequences against and two for pluralism, uses Jain conditional predication analytically, and closes with a balanced verdict plus its alethic qualification.

### Question-shaped timed-paper compression plan

Under time pressure, protect the element the directive is grading and cut the element that merely displays reading.

| Printed demand                              | Protect                                                              | Cut first                                 |
|---------------------------------------------|----------------------------------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------------|
| 2018 Q6(a) distinguish E-I-P                | "Who sets the terms" for each of the three                           | The three conciliar dates                 |
| 2018 Q6(b) "Truth is one..." Indian context | The context clause and RV 1.164.46 discipline                        | The Jain apparatus, to one sentence       |
| 2019 Q5(b) uniting force                    | The three conditions                                                 | The list of universalist doctrines        |
| 2019 Q7(a) central problem                  | The single-sentence statement of the problem; Plantinga with D'Costa | Hick's four steps, to two clauses         |
| 2020 Q5(c) conflict history                 | Cause / marker / mobiliser / legitimiser                             | The counter-evidence list, to three items |
| 2020 Q5(e) tolerance                        | Three components and Forst's ladder                                  | Mill, Rawls and Popper, to one clause     |
| 2021 Q5(b) absolute truth possibility       | The compatibility mechanism                                          | Two of the three denials of the premise   |
| 2021 Q5(c) religious freedom                | The internal-minorities paradox                                      | Three of the four justifications          |
| 2022 Q7(a) absolute truth -> exclusivism    | The formal reconstruction with the suppressed premise                | One of the three denials                  |
| 2023 Q8(b) two allegations                  | The explicit separation of the two charges                           | The four-role analysis, to one clause     |
| 2024 Q5(b) notion of absolute truth         | The four-way separation                                              | One of the two consequences               |
| 2025 Q7(a) Vedāntic pluralism               | Vivekananda's own theses and the contested assimilation objection    | The Jain addition, to one clause          |

### Self-scoring and next steps

Score each attempt on five bands. **Weak** - E-I-P named, "all religions lead to the same God". **Average** - E-I-P correctly distinguished, Hick and Vivekananda present, but exclusivism presented only as bigotry. **Good** - truth, salvation, access and coexistence separated and one objection answered. **Strong** - Plantinga stated and met; RV 1.164.46 and Cyprian handled correctly; many-sidedness used as a logic. **Top** - all of that, plus one discriminating distinction (Forst's ladder, Heim against Hick, D'Costa's charge, or epistemic-versus-alethic unresolvability) and an explicit acknowledgement of the hard contradictions pluralism cannot dissolve.

If two consecutive attempts land below **Good**, return to Sessions 1, 14 and 15 before attempting another 20-marker: the fault is almost always a merged axis or an unconceded contradiction rather than missing content.

### Independence note

Every model answer, original question, diagnostic item and option explanation in this package is **independent learner practice**. None reproduces an official mark scheme, and none should be presented as one. Only the twelve previous-year questions are reproduced verbatim, from the audited repository ledger, and they are reproduced for practice routing.